



TALENTLOCK

EXCLUSIVE TALENT INFRASTRUCTURE

COMMERCIAL STRATEGY & SALES BRIEF

Market Positioning & Revenue Architecture

A go-to-market assessment of the TalentLock platform: what it sells, who buys it, why it wins, and how it monetises. **48 shipped capabilities** mapped to buyer value, a **six-tier plan architecture** audited against the code that enforces it, and a candid account of what must ship before the platform can charge.

48

SELLABLE
CAPABILITIES

2

SIDES OF THE
MARKETPLACE

6

PLAN TIERS
DEFINED

4

REVENUE
BLOCKERS

\$0

COLLECTED
TO DATE

BASIS OF ASSESSMENT

main @ 23d405b

DOCUMENT CLASS

Commercial Strategy · Confidential

REVISION

18 August 2026

PART

Table of Contents

Seven commercial parts and three appendices. Product claims in this document are verified against the source tree; market and pricing judgements are labelled as such.

01	Commercial Summary	03
	The proposition in one page, what is actually being sold, an honest commercial readiness scorecard, and the headline commercial facts.	
	1.1 The Proposition 1.2 What We Sell 1.3 Readiness Scorecard 1.4 Commercial Facts	
02	Market Problem & Positioning	06
	The trust gap in freelance hiring, the cost of the status quo, category positioning against adjacent tooling, competitive differentiation, and defensibility.	
	2.1 The Trust Gap 2.2 Cost of Status Quo 2.3 Category Position 2.4 Competitive Matrix 2.5 Defensibility	
03	Buyers, Segments & Qualification	10
	Two-sided market dynamics, employer and professional ideal customer profiles, buying-committee personas, the education vertical wedge, and a qualification framework for the sales team.	
	3.1 Two-Sided Dynamics 3.2 Employer ICP 3.3 Buying Committee 3.4 Supply-Side ICP 3.5 Education Wedge 3.6 Qualification	
04	Value Architecture — Features as Commercial Assets	14
	Four value pillars, every capability mapped from feature to benefit to quantified buyer value, and a classification of which features acquire, retain, and expand revenue.	
	4.1 Four Pillars 4.2 Value Mapping 4.3 Acquire / Retain / Expand 4.4 Demo Narrative	
05	Packaging, Pricing & Revenue Architecture	19
	Plan architecture as enforced in code, value-metric analysis, the entitlement gating map, land-and-expand mechanics, AI cost-to-serve and gross margin, and pricing recommendations.	
	5.1 Plans As Built 5.2 Value Metric 5.3 Gating Map 5.4 Land & Expand 5.5 Cost to Serve 5.6 Recommendations	
06	Sales Enablement	23
	The narrative arc and demo sequence, discovery questions by persona, objection handling with evidence, proof points, and competitive traps.	
	6.1 Narrative Arc 6.2 Discovery Questions 6.3 Objection Handling 6.4 Proof Points 6.5 Competitive Traps	
07	Go-to-Market & Commercial Readiness	27
	Motion by segment, the activation funnel and its conversion levers, the revenue blockers that must clear before charging, and a commercial risk register.	
	7.1 Motion by Segment 7.2 Activation Funnel 7.3 Revenue Blockers 7.4 Risk Register	
A	Appendices	30
	Complete capability-to-value index, the as-built plan comparison matrix, and claims discipline for customer-facing teams.	
	A. Capability Index · 30 B. Plan Matrix · 32 C. Claims Discipline · 34	

EVIDENCE STANDARD USED IN THIS DOCUMENT

Every product capability claim was verified against the repository at `main @ 23d405b` — plan limits from `artifacts/api-server/src/lib/plans.ts`, entitlement behaviour from `subscriptionGating.ts` and `planAccess.ts`, and buyer-visible copy from `artifacts/talentlock/src/pages/Pricing.tsx`.

Market sizing figures are deliberately omitted. No first-party market research, funnel data, win/loss history, or customer telemetry exists in this repository, so any TAM or conversion-rate number here would be invented. Where commercial judgement is offered it is labelled **Recommendation** or **Assumption** and the reasoning is shown so it can be challenged.

COMPANION DOCUMENT

This brief is the commercial counterpart to **TalentLock — System Architecture & Component Reference** (teal edition), which covers the same platform from an engineering perspective. Where this document asserts that a capability exists, the architecture brief identifies the module that implements it.

PART
01

Commercial Summary

What the business sells, to whom, on what commercial terms — and an unvarnished view of how close the platform is to collecting revenue.

1.1 The Proposition

TalentLock sells **certainty in freelance hiring**. It is not a job board and not a staffing agency. It is the transactional system of record for an engagement — from discovery through verification, negotiation, contract, delivery, and retrospective — with **exclusivity** and **verified identity** enforced by the platform rather than promised by the counterparty.

The commercial insight is that buyers of specialist freelance talent are not short of **candidates**; they are short of **confidence**. The expensive failures in freelance hiring happen after the match: the contractor takes a second engagement mid-project, the credential turns out to be unverified or expired, the contract is an email thread, the scope was never written down, and nobody can say afterwards whether the engagement was actually good value. Marketplaces optimise the match and disengage precisely where the risk begins.

TalentLock monetises that gap. Its differentiated assets are the **exclusivity lock** (a booked professional is made unavailable by the system, with availability blocks written automatically), **bilateral verification** (both employer and professional present tiered, AI-adjudicated identity and credential badges, with expiry tracked on a 90/30/7-day alert ladder), and a **complete contract lifecycle** (AI drafting or upload, redlining, a five-dimension health score, plain-English summarisation, dual e-signature, and a certified PDF) that never requires leaving the platform.

THE ONE-SENTENCE PITCH

TalentLock is where you hire a specialist and know they are actually yours — verified, exclusively committed, under a signed contract, with the whole engagement recorded in one place instead of scattered across a marketplace, an inbox, and a folder of PDFs.

1.2 What We Are Actually Selling

Commercially it is important to be precise about the unit of value, because it determines how the product is priced and how a sales conversation should be framed. TalentLock sells four distinct things, in descending order of willingness to pay.

SELL 01

Risk removal

Exclusivity enforcement, bilateral verification, credential expiry monitoring, and a signed enforceable agreement for every engagement.

Buyer pays to avoid a failed engagement

SELL 02

Time compression

AI matching, autonomous outreach agents, AI-drafted contracts, generated meeting briefs and proposals — hours of manual work removed per engagement.

Buyer pays to reclaim hiring-manager time

SELL 03

Decision quality

Rate benchmarking against market and historical spend, contract health scoring, hiring funnel analytics, and post-engagement debriefs.

Buyer pays to stop overpaying and re-hiring badly

SELL 04

System of record

One auditable place holding contracts, signatures, credentials, messages, spend, and outcomes across every engagement.

Buyer pays for auditability and continuity

The supply side buys something different and narrower: **qualified inbound demand without bidding**.

Professionals pay to be found, to be visibly verified, and to have an autonomous agent pitch on their behalf while they work — not to browse listings.

1.3 Commercial Readiness Scorecard

The product is materially further along than the commercial apparatus around it. The distinction matters for forecasting: **capability is not the constraint on revenue; collection and claim integrity are.**

COMMERCIAL DIMENSION	STATUS	EVIDENCE
Product breadth	READY	48 feature domains shipped across both sides of the marketplace, backed by 37 written specifications.
Differentiated capability	READY	Exclusivity lock, bilateral verification, full contract lifecycle, and two autonomous outreach agents — none of which are table stakes in adjacent tooling.
AI depth	READY	20 metered inference surfaces embedded in workflow, each with per-account cost attribution in a single accounting table.
Multi-currency & international	READY	Country-derived currency, booking currency frozen with an FX snapshot, dual-currency display — no re-platforming needed to sell outside one market.
Vertical differentiation	READY	Education vertical carries a dedicated profile model, DBS status, teaching licence expiry enforcement, and subject/level matching.
Entitlement enforcement	BUILT, OFF	Plan ceilings and token quotas are fully implemented and unit-tested, then bypassed wholesale by the <code>PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE</code> flag, which is currently on.
Usage telemetry for CS	PARTIAL	Per-account, per-feature token consumption and activity ledgers exist. There is no product-analytics instrumentation, funnel tracking, or health scoring.
Payment collection	BLOCKER	Upgrade is a simulated transition. Stripe columns are reserved on <code>subscriptions</code> but no processor is integrated. The platform cannot take money today.
Advertised-vs-built parity	BLOCKER	Four capabilities are listed on the live pricing page but not implemented — see the risk note below. This is a mis-selling exposure, not a roadmap gap.
Published pricing accuracy	BLOCKER	Internal documentation and the enforcing code disagree on four of six plans' limits. Any quote built from the wrong source is wrong.
Abuse & margin protection	BLOCKER	No global rate limit on AI endpoints. With quotas disabled, inference cost per account is currently unbounded.

MATERIAL COMMERCIAL RISK — SELLING WHAT IS NOT BUILT

The pricing page renders each plan's `features` array verbatim to prospects. Four entries describe capabilities that do not exist in the codebase:

- **SSO / SCIM** (Enterprise) — authentication is Clerk-based; no SAML or SCIM provisioning path exists anywhere in the tree.
- **Audit log export** (Enterprise) — an `audit_logs` table and a platform-admin view exist, but there is no customer-facing export.
- **Priority placement in Vault search** (Freelancer Pro) — no ranking logic anywhere reads the subscription plan.
- **Verified Pro badge on profile** (Freelancer Pro) — badges are derived from verified documents, not from plan tier.

Two of these sit in the **Enterprise** tier, which is precisely where they will be written into a contract and diligenced by a security reviewer. **Remove or build them before the first enterprise conversation.** Of the four, SSO/SCIM is the only one likely to be a genuine deal-breaker for that segment, and it is also the most expensive to deliver.

1.4 Headline Commercial Facts

48 SELLABLE CAPABILITIES Both marketplace sides	\$49 ONLY LIVE PRICE Employer Starter, per month	20 METERED AI SURFACES Per-account attribution	5x TOKEN HEADROOM Starter 50k → Growth 250k	4 REVENUE BLOCKERS All non-architectural
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Monetisation Posture At A Glance

MODEL SaaS subscription	SIDES CHARGED Both (asymmetric)	TAKE RATE ON WORK None	PAYMENTS IN SCOPE No	CONTRACT TERM Monthly
PRIMARY VALUE METRIC Active bookings	SECONDARY METRIC AI tokens / month	SEAT EXPANSION Enterprise only	GATES ACTIVE No — flag open	REVENUE TO DATE \$0

THE COMMERCIAL HEADLINE

TalentLock has built an **enterprise-grade product on a pre-revenue commercial chassis**. The capability inventory would credibly support a \$49–\$199 per seat-month employer subscription today. What stands between the product and its first invoice is a payment integration, one configuration flag, and the removal of four unbuilt claims — **days of commercial work, not quarters of engineering**. That asymmetry is the single most important fact in this document.

PART
02

Market Problem & Positioning

The buyer problem in its own language, the cost of leaving it unsolved, and where TalentLock sits relative to the tools a prospect is already paying for.

2.1 The Trust Gap

Freelance hiring has abundant supply and almost no assurance. The market has solved **finding** people and left **relying** on them entirely to the buyer.

A hiring manager engaging a specialist contractor today runs an unmanaged risk portfolio. Five failure modes recur, and none of them are addressed by the platform that made the introduction.

FIGURE 2.1 — WHERE FREELANCE ENGAGEMENTS FAIL, AND WHO CURRENTLY OWNS THE RISK

STAGE	FAILURE MODE	WHO OWNS IT TODAY
Discovery	Volume without signal – hundreds of profiles, no verified differentiation	Buyer, manually
Vetting	Credentials asserted, not verified. Licences and checks silently expire	Nobody
Commitment	Contractor takes a parallel engagement mid-project	Nobody
Contracting	Terms live in an email thread or a template nobody reviewed	Buyer, or their lawyer
Retrospective	No record of whether the engagement was good value or worth repeating	Nobody

TalentLock owns all five. Exclusivity and verification are enforced by the system; contracting and retrospective are first-class product surfaces.

The three "nobody" rows are the commercial opening. They are precisely the failures a buyer has learned to absorb because no vendor has offered to carry them.

POSITIONING CONSEQUENCE

Because the differentiation sits **after** the match, TalentLock should never be sold on the strength of its matching. Every marketplace claims good matching and buyers have learned to discount the claim. Lead instead with the **exclusivity lock** — it is concrete, demonstrable in thirty seconds, and no incumbent offers it.

2.2 The Cost of the Status Quo

Buyers rarely have a line item called "freelance hiring risk", so the value has to be constructed with them during discovery. The framework below is the arithmetic to walk a prospect through. The **inputs come from the prospect** — the platform supplies the structure, not the numbers.

COST CENTRE	HOW IT IS INCURRED TODAY	WHAT TALENTLOCK CHANGES
Failed engagement	A contractor is unavailable, under-qualified, or exits mid-project. Cost is the sunk fee plus re-hiring plus the delivery slip.	Exclusivity is enforced in the schema and credentials are AI-verified before engagement. The two most common causes are removed structurally.

COST CENTRE	HOW IT IS INCURRED TODAY	WHAT TALENTLOCK CHANGES
Hiring-manager time	Screening, chasing references, drafting scope, negotiating by email, writing the contract, chasing signatures.	AI matching with explanations, AI-drafted contracts, generated meeting briefs, in-platform negotiation and e-signature. Measured in hours per engagement.
Rate leakage	No visibility into market rate or the organisation's own historical spend, so each rate is negotiated from zero.	Rate benchmarking against market median and the employer's own history, surfaced at the moment of negotiation.
Legal exposure	Unreviewed templates, missing IP or termination clauses, unverifiable signature trails.	Contract health scored across five dimensions, AI redlining, dual e-signature with stored signature images and timestamps, certified PDF.
Compliance risk	Expired professional licences or background checks go unnoticed until an audit or an incident.	Expiry tracked with a 90/30/7-day alert ladder; lapsed credentials downgrade the badge automatically and, in the education vertical, remove the profile from the Vault.
Institutional amnesia	When the hiring manager leaves, the knowledge of who was good and why leaves with them.	Reviews, post-engagement AI debriefs with rehire recommendations, candidate hiring files, and retained spend and outcome analytics.

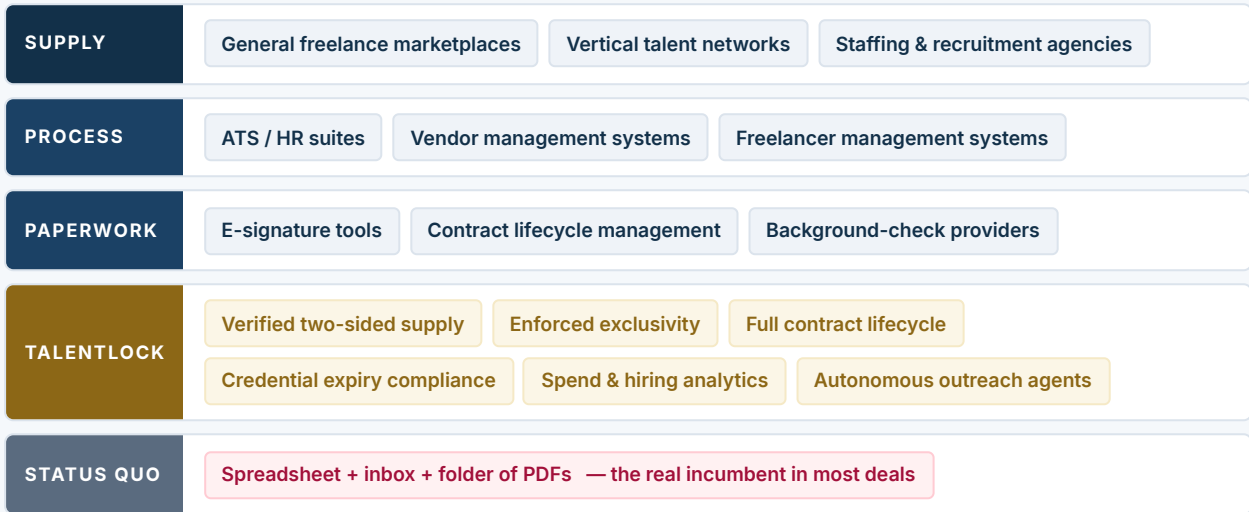
DISCOVERY TECHNIQUE — MAKE THE BUYER DO THE ARITHMETIC

The strongest version of this conversation is not a slide. Ask three questions and let the prospect compute the number themselves: "How many contractor engagements did you run last year?" · "How many went wrong enough that you had to re-hire or slip a date?" · "What did one of those cost you, all in?" A single prevented failure typically dwarfs an annual subscription, which reframes the pricing conversation from cost to insurance before pricing is ever discussed.

2.3 Category Positioning

TalentLock overlaps several categories without belonging to any of them. That is commercially useful — it means there is rarely a like-for-like incumbent to be displaced — but it is also a risk, because prospects will try to file the product under something familiar and budget for it accordingly.

FIGURE 2.3 — ADJACENT CATEGORIES AND THE GROUND TALENTLOCK OCCUPIES



POSITIONING RISK — BEING MIS-FILED

If a prospect files TalentLock as "another marketplace" it will be benchmarked against a zero-subscription, take-rate model and lose on price. If filed as "e-signature plus a directory" it will be benchmarked against a low per-seat tool.

The category to claim is engagement assurance — the system of record for contractor engagements — because that framing carries a compliance-and-risk budget rather than a tools budget. Insist on that frame early; it is very hard to change after the first pricing discussion.

2.4 Competitive Differentiation Matrix

Compared by capability against category archetypes rather than named vendors, since individual vendor feature sets change and no first-party competitive research exists in this repository.

CAPABILITY	FREELANCE MARKETPLACE	STAFFING AGENCY	ATS / HR SUITE	CLM / E-SIGN	TALENTLOCK	COMMERCIAL READ
Talent discovery	✓	✓	~	×	✓	Table stakes — do not lead here
AI matching with rationale	~	×	~	×	✓	Differentiated but widely claimed
Verified identity, both sides	~	✓	×	×	✓	Agency-grade trust without agency margin
Enforced exclusivity	×	~	×	×	✓	Unique — lead with this
Credential expiry monitoring	×	~	~	×	✓	Compliance budget unlock
In-platform rate negotiation	~	×	×	×	✓	Keeps the transaction on-platform
AI contract drafting	×	×	×	~	✓	Displaces legal review cycles
Contract quality scoring	×	×	×	~	✓	Strong with legal stakeholders
Dual e-signature + certified PDF	×	~	×	✓	✓	Removes a separate line item
Spend & hiring analytics	×	×	✓	×	✓	Wins finance and procurement
Post-engagement retrospective	×	×	~	×	✓	Rare; drives renewal narrative
Autonomous outreach agents	×	~	×	×	✓	Replaces the agency's core labour
No take rate on the work	×	×	✓	✓	✓	Decisive against agencies
Payment & escrow	✓	✓	×	×	✗	Our gap — see 6.3

CAPABILITY	FREELANCE MARKETPLACE	STAFFING AGENCY	ATS / HR SUITE	CLM / E-SIGN	TALENTLOCK	COMMERCIAL READ
SSO / SCIM provisioning	×	×	✓	✓	×	Our gap — blocks enterprise

✓ core capability · ~ partial or varies by vendor · × absent. Archetype assessments reflect category norms and should be replaced with vendor-specific research before being used in a competitive deal.

2.5 Defensibility

Feature parity is achievable by a funded competitor. The durable advantages are the ones that compound with usage or would require a rival to rebuild a data model rather than ship a screen.

STRONG Two-sided verified graph

Verification is bilateral and tiered, with expiry state machines on both credentials and teaching licences. A competitor can add document upload in a sprint; accumulating a population of **currently verified, non-expired** professionals takes calendar time that cannot be compressed.

STRONG Engagement history as a data asset

Rate benchmarking, spend analytics, retention metrics, and rehire recommendations all improve with completed engagements. This is a genuine switching cost: leaving means losing the organisation's own negotiating history and outcome record.

MODERATE Exclusivity as a schema invariant

Copyable in principle, but it constrains a marketplace's core incentive. An incumbent monetising volume through a take rate is structurally reluctant to make its highest-earning supply unavailable. This is a **business-model** moat more than a technical one.

MODERATE Vertical depth in education

Teaching profession types, subject and level matching, DBS status, and licence-expiry-driven Vault exclusion are modelled in the schema rather than bolted on. A horizontal competitor would need a vertical data model to match it.

WEAK AI features in isolation

Drafting, summarisation, and scoring are commodity capabilities over commodity models. They are valuable as **workflow embedding** — twenty surfaces sitting exactly where the decision is made — not as differentiators in their own right. **Never sell "we have AI".**

ABSENT Network effects across employers

Nothing yet makes the platform more valuable to Employer A because Employer B uses it — no shared reputation signal, benchmark pool, or portable trust score. This is the most significant strategic gap and the clearest candidate for the next moat-building investment.

PART 03

Buyers, Segments & Qualification

Who pays, who champions, who blocks, and how a sales team decides quickly whether an opportunity is real.

3.1 Two-Sided Dynamics

Both sides are monetised, but asymmetrically and for different reasons. Getting this asymmetry right is the difference between a marketplace that fills and one that stalls.

DIMENSION	EMPLOYER SIDE (DEMAND)	PROFESSIONAL SIDE (SUPPLY)
Buys	Risk removal and time compression	Qualified inbound demand without bidding
Willingness to pay	High — cost of failure is large and attributable	Low — treated as a marketing expense
Live price	\$49/mo Starter; Growth and Enterprise not yet priced live	\$0 — Pro tier temporarily free
Value metric	Active bookings, then AI tokens	Express-interest volume and outreach capacity
Churn trigger	A quarter with no hiring need	No inbound interest received
Strategic role	Revenue	Inventory — must be seeded ahead of demand

RECOMMENDATION — DO NOT RUSH TO MONETISE SUPPLY

Freelancer Pro currently lists at **\$0** (previously \$19). Keeping it free longer is likely the correct commercial choice: supply liquidity is the precondition for every employer deal, and the Vault has a hard quality gate at `completenessScore ≥ 60` that already filters low-effort profiles without charging for it. Charging supply too early suppresses the inventory that demand-side revenue depends on. Revisit only once employer demand demonstrably exceeds available verified supply in a given category.

Note also that two of the four Pro benefits currently advertised — priority Vault placement and a Pro badge — **are not implemented**, so the tier cannot presently be sold with integrity at any price.

3.2 Employer Ideal Customer Profile

ATTRIBUTE	BEST FIT	POOR FIT
Engagement pattern	Recurring specialist engagements — several per quarter, each material enough that failure is visible	One-off micro-tasks, or continuous full-time headcount
Engagement value	High enough that exclusivity and a real contract matter	Small commodity tasks where speed beats assurance
Organisation size	Founder-led through mid-market; 1-3 hiring seats	Large enterprise requiring SSO and procurement integration today
Compliance posture	Regulated or credential-sensitive — education, healthcare-adjacent, professional services	No credential requirements whatsoever
Current process	Spreadsheet, inbox, and ad-hoc contract templates	Established VMS or FMS with procurement already integrated
Pain evidence	Can name a specific engagement that failed and what it cost	Cannot recall a problem worth solving

ATTRIBUTE	BEST FIT	POOR FIT
Geography	Any — multi-currency and country/state modelling already shipped	Markets requiring localised payroll or statutory employment handling

SHARPEST EMPLOYER SEGMENT

Education institutions and tutoring organisations hiring teaching professionals. They combine recurring specialist demand, a legally material credential requirement (teaching licences, DBS checks), and an acute exclusivity problem — a tutor or lecturer double-booking is an immediate service failure. This is the only segment where the product's compliance features are not a nice-to-have but the reason to buy. See 3.5.

3.3 The Buying Committee

Even in mid-market deals, three to five people touch the decision. Each cares about a different subset of the product, and the champion is rarely the person who blocks.

CHAMPION Hiring Manager		Head of Engineering · Head of School · Delivery Lead
PAIN	Carries the delivery date personally. Has been burned by a contractor who became unavailable or misrepresented experience. Spends hours screening and chasing paperwork that is not their job.	
WINS WITH	Exclusivity lock · AI match explanations · AI meeting brief with suggested questions · verified credential badges · watchlist pipeline	
HOOK	"When you book someone here, the platform makes them unavailable to everyone else and writes the availability block itself. They are actually yours."	

ECONOMIC BUYER Founder / COO / Finance		Signs the subscription
PAIN	Contractor spend is real money with no visibility. Cannot answer what was spent, with whom, at what rate, or whether it was good value. Rates are negotiated inconsistently across the team.	
WINS WITH	Spend analytics with field breakdown and committed spend · rate benchmarking against market and own history · hiring funnel and retention analytics · predictable subscription with no take rate	
HOOK	"A flat subscription instead of an agency percentage — and for the first time, a rate benchmark and a spend trend you can actually take to a board meeting."	

BLOCKER Legal / Compliance		Can veto; rarely champions
PAIN	Contractor agreements are unreviewed templates. IP assignment and termination clauses are inconsistent. Signature trails are unverifiable. Expired professional credentials are discovered during audits, not before.	
WINS WITH	Five-dimension contract health score · AI redlining · dual e-signature with stored images and timestamps · certified PDF · credential expiry alert ladder · audit logging · GDPR deletion with active-engagement guard	
WATCH	Will ask about data residency, retention, sub-processors, and breach process. The architecture supports the answers; there is no security documentation pack to hand over. Prepare one before entering regulated deals.	

BLOCKER IT / Security Review		Enterprise deals only
PAIN	Another SaaS tool holding personal data and identity documents, outside centralised identity management.	
BLOCKS ON	SSO / SCIM — advertised on the pricing page but not built. This will surface in the first enterprise security review and, if it was quoted, will cost credibility as well as the deal. Also expect requests for audit log export (also advertised, also not built), penetration test results, and an uptime commitment — none of which exist today.	
CAN WIN WITH	Per-resource authorisation, deny-by-default private object storage, admin CSRF protection, field redaction in logs, and audit trails — all genuinely implemented and defensible under scrutiny.	

INFLUENCER Talent / HR Operations		Owns the process; may feel displaced
PAIN	Coordinates hiring across managers with no shared pipeline. Chases documents and signatures. Cannot report on contractor hiring alongside permanent hiring.	
WINS WITH	Shared team shortlist · team seats and invitations · team-level analytics · document review queues · hiring funnel reporting	
WATCH	Shared shortlist and team analytics are Enterprise-gated . In a Starter or Growth deal this persona gets comparatively little, and an unaddressed HR Ops stakeholder is a common cause of stalled mid-market deals.	

3.4 Supply-Side Ideal Profile

Supply quality determines whether demand-side value is deliverable. Two archetypes matter; the platform's gates already select for both.

INDEPENDENT SPECIALIST Fits: senior technology or professional-services contractor, works on a small number of substantial engagements, wants inbound demand without competing on price. Signals: completes the profile past the 60% gate, uploads credentials, activates Cruise Mode.	TEACHING PROFESSIONAL Fits: school teacher, university lecturer, tutor, or researcher with a licence and background check to evidence. Signals: supplies teaching subjects and levels, licence expiry, and DBS status — all first-class schema fields rather than free text.	DOES NOT FIT High-volume commodity task workers. The exclusivity model actively penalises them — a booking removes their availability — and the verification burden exceeds the value of a small engagement.
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3.5 The Education Vertical — Sharpest Wedge

Education is the one segment where TalentLock's compliance machinery is not a differentiator but a **requirement**. That converts a “nice product” conversation into a “how do you currently prove this” conversation.

VERTICAL REQUIREMENT	PLATFORM CAPABILITY	COMMERCIAL LEVERAGE
Right-to-work and background checks	Identity document verification with AI adjudication; <code>dbCheckStatus</code> as a first-class field; rules can require verified DBS before outreach	Turns a legal obligation into a product feature the institution can evidence in an inspection

VERTICAL REQUIREMENT	PLATFORM CAPABILITY	COMMERCIAL LEVERAGE
Current teaching licence	<code>teachingLicenceExpiry</code> with a monotonic alert ladder; expired school-teacher licences are removed from the Vault automatically	Removes the possibility of engaging an unlicensed teacher — the single highest-consequence failure in this segment
Subject and level matching	<code>teachingSubjects</code> and <code>teachingLevels</code> arrays with dedicated filters and AI prompt context	Demonstrates the product was built for education rather than adapted to it
Role differentiation	Four profession types — school teacher, university lecturer, tutor, researcher — each with its own required-document set	Credible vertical depth; hard for a horizontal competitor to answer quickly
Session-based commercials	Rate types of <code>per_session</code> and <code>per_course</code> alongside hourly and daily	Prices the way the segment actually buys, avoiding an immediate objection
No double-booking	Exclusivity lock plus availability calendar with immutable booking-derived blocks	Directly addresses the segment's most visible operational failure

RECOMMENDATION — LEAD WITH EDUCATION

Concentrating early go-to-market on education produces a compounding advantage: it is the segment where the differentiators are mandatory, where the buyer has a named compliance owner with budget, and where a reference customer is most persuasive to the next prospect. Horizontal technology contracting is a larger pool but a much flatter, more crowded sale in which the exclusivity argument competes against price.

3.6 Qualification Framework

A deal is qualified when four conditions hold. Any missing condition predicts a specific, known failure mode.

#	CONDITION	EVIDENCE TO OBTAIN	IF ABSENT
1	Recurring specialist demand	A number of engagements per quarter, and named roles	No renewal case — they will churn after one hire
2	A remembered failure	A specific engagement that went wrong and its cost	No urgency; the deal will slip indefinitely
3	Compliance or exclusivity stake	Credential requirements, or a double-booking incident	Product is over-specified; they will buy a cheaper directory
4	Budget owner engaged	Founder, COO, or Finance in the conversation	Champion cannot buy; expect a stall at procurement

Disqualify early on any of these

- **SSO or SCIM is a stated requirement.** It is advertised but not built. Disqualify or scope explicitly as a roadmap commitment with dates — never imply it exists.
- **Escrow or platform payment is required.** Payments are entirely out of scope; there is no processor integration.
- **Procurement demands an uptime SLA or penetration test report.** Neither exists today; no monitoring is instrumented to support an availability commitment.
- **The buyer wants a take-rate or success-fee model.** The product is a subscription; no billing mechanism exists to support transactional pricing.

PART
04

Value Architecture — Features as Commercial Assets

Every shipped capability translated from engineering fact into buyer benefit, then classified by the commercial job it performs.

4.1 The Four Value Pillars

Forty-eight features is unsellable as a list. It is sellable as four promises, each with a small number of proof features behind it.

PILLAR 01**They are actually yours**

Exclusivity enforced by the system, availability calendar with immutable booking blocks, rate convergence gating, and a signed agreement before work starts.

Answers: will they still be here next week?

PILLAR 02**They are who they say**

Bilateral AI-adjudicated document verification, tiered badges, credential and licence expiry ladder, DBS status, reviews and ratings.

Answers: can I evidence this in an audit?

PILLAR 03**The paperwork is done**

AI drafting or upload, amendments, enrichment, redlining, five-dimension health score, plain-English summary, dual e-signature, certified PDF.

Answers: who is writing the contract?

PILLAR 04**You will know if it worked**

Rate benchmarking, spend analytics, hiring funnel and retention metrics, AI meeting briefs, post-engagement debriefs with rehire recommendations.

Answers: was that good value?

4.2 Feature-to-Value Mapping

Grouped by pillar. The **value** column is deliberately written in the buyer's language — what changes for them, not what the software does.

Pillar 1 — Commitment & exclusivity

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
Exclusive Bookings	A confirmed booking marks the professional unavailable and writes an availability block automatically	Eliminates mid-project loss to a competing engagement — the most expensive failure mode	ALL
Availability Calendar	Manual and booking-derived blocks; booking-derived blocks cannot be deleted; next-available date surfaced on search cards	Stop discovering unavailability after making an offer	ALL
Rate Negotiation	Alternating proposals; agreement generation blocked until both sides converge	No engagement begins on an unagreed rate	ALL
Milestone Tracking	Title, amount, due date, and status per milestone	Delivery is visible without a status meeting	ALL
Job Timeline Validation	End dates must be on or after start dates, enforced in form and API	Removes a small but recurring source of scheduling disputes	ALL

Pillar 2 — Verified trust

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
Document Verification	AI vision review of identity and credential documents with a confidence score; low confidence escalates to human review	Credentials are checked, not asserted — without building a vetting team	ALL
Employer Verification	Five business document types; tiered employer badge recalculated on every status change; Representative ID mandatory at registration	Professionals can see the employer is real — improves response rates to outreach	ALL
Credential Expiry Tracking	Daily scan advancing a 90/30/7-day alert ladder; lapsed credentials downgrade the badge; expired teaching licences leave the Vault	Compliance becomes continuous instead of a point-in-time check	ALL
Teaching Professional Profile	Four profession types, subject and level arrays, licence state and expiry, DBS status, per-type required documents	Education hiring is modelled properly rather than forced into a generic profile	ALL
Reviews & Ratings	One review per completed booking with an optional single reply	Reputation grounded in completed engagements, not unverifiable testimonials	ALL
Profile Completeness Gate	Profiles below 60% completeness are invisible in the Vault	Search results contain only genuinely evaluable candidates	ALL
Public Profiles	Unauthenticated shareable profile pages with read-only availability	Professionals can be referenced externally; a light organic acquisition channel	ALL

Pillar 3 — Contract lifecycle

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
AI Agreement Generation	Drafts a contract from booking particulars and industry clause templates in the booking's currency	A real contract in minutes without legal drafting time	ALL
Employer Uploaded Agreement	Upload PDF/DOCX/TXT, AI summary, amendment points, AI enrichment with booking terms, then finalisation	Organisations keep their own paper and still get the platform's workflow	ALL
Contract Health Score	0–100 composite across Clarity, Fairness, Completeness, Enforceability, Industry Fit, with an A–F grade	Non-lawyers can judge contract quality; strong with legal stakeholders	ALL
Contract Redlining	AI edit suggestions; accepting one invalidates dependent AI caches atomically	Improve terms without a legal review cycle	GROWTH
Agreement AI Summary	Six-section plain-English digest with attention flags, freelancer-only	Professionals sign understanding the terms — fewer disputes later	ALL
Signature & Safe Locker	Stored signature images reused across agreements; certified download unlocked when fully executed	Signing without a separate e-signature subscription	ALL
Agreement PDF Download	Formatted PDF with both signatures, timestamps, and metadata; cached after first generation	An artefact that satisfies finance, legal, and audit	ALL

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
Agreement Templates	Industry-specific templates; custom clauses for enterprise	Consistent terms across every engagement in the organisation	ENT

Pillar 4 — Decision quality & intelligence

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
Smart Rate Suggestions	Market median and the employer's own historical average at the moment of negotiation; AI recommendation on Growth	Stop overpaying and stop losing candidates by underbidding	GROWTH
Spend Analytics	Spend trend, field breakdown, top professionals by spend, committed spend, rate vs market	Contractor spend becomes reportable to a board	ALL
Hiring Analytics	Funnel conversion, skills demand/supply gap, retention rate, lifecycle duration, outcome breakdown	Manage contractor hiring as a process rather than a series of favours	ALL
AI Meeting Brief	Five-section brief on confirmation — candidate snapshot, match rationale, suggested questions, rate context, watch points	Every interview is prepared, even when the manager had no time to prepare	GROWTH
Discovery Meeting Outcome	Internal notes with a disposition; AI handoff summary for next-round; candidate hiring file on final decisions	Interview knowledge is retained by the organisation, not the interviewer	ALL
Post-Engagement AI Debrief	Dual role-specific retrospective with a rehire recommendation, generated on completion	Institutional memory of who was worth rehire	GROWTH
Earnings Intelligence	Six-month trend vs platform average, rate percentile, projection, top earning skills	Supply-side retention — the reason professionals keep the profile current	ALL
AI Token Tracking	Monthly consumption by feature; per-conversation breakdown on Growth	AI spend is transparent rather than an opaque platform cost	GROWTH

Acceleration & workflow

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
AI Talent Matching	Conversational matching that reads job requirements and recommends candidates	Describe the need instead of filtering a directory	ALL
Smarter Matching	Per-candidate explanation across skills, rate, and availability	Recommendations that can be justified to a colleague	ALL
TalentSearch agent	Autonomously evaluates profiles as they change and sends AI-authored outreach under strict budget, duplicate, and recipient caps	Sourcing continues while the hiring manager does other work	ALL
Cruise Mode agent	Freelancer-side mirror — evaluates every new posting and pitches on the professional's behalf	Supply-side liquidity without professionals monitoring the platform	PRO

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT DOES	BUYER VALUE	TIER
Freelancer Watchlist	Personal pipeline with private notes; alerts on availability and ≥5% rate change	Warm bench for the next requirement instead of starting from scratch	STARTER
Talent Vault	Filter by field, rate, availability window, keyword, profession category, teaching subject	Fast shortlisting from pre-qualified supply	ALL
Job Description Assistant	AI generate, improve, and check modes	Better postings attract better candidates; removes blank-page friction	ALL
AI Proposal Generator	Three-tone drafting for professionals responding to bookings	Supply-side conversion; better-quality responses to employers	ALL
Direct Messaging	Employer↔professional threads scoped to bookings or meetings, with unread tracking and rate limiting	Conversation stays attached to the engagement instead of in personal email	ALL
Notifications Centre	Fifteen event triggers, in-app plus email with opt-out	Nothing waits on someone remembering to check	ALL
Engagement Lists	Server-side search, filter, and pagination across six list surfaces	Usable at volume — a retention feature, not a demo feature	ALL
Multi-Currency & Location	Country-derived currency, booking currency frozen with FX snapshot, dual-currency display	Hire across borders without spreadsheet conversion or restated history	ALL
Team Accounts	Team creation, single-use expiring invites, shared shortlist, team analytics	Coordinated hiring across managers with consolidated reporting	ENT
Portfolio	Portfolio items with images, links, and tags	Evidence of work quality alongside verified identity	ALL
Security & Auth Hardening	Per-resource authorisation, deny-by-default object access, admin CSRF, log redaction, audit logging, GDPR deletion	Survives a security questionnaire — an enabler for regulated buyers	ALL
Admin Console	Document review queues, platform statistics, audit log, token attribution	Internal — makes human-in-the-loop verification operable at scale	INTERNAL

NOTE ON THE TIER COLUMN

Tiers above reflect the gates **as written in code**. Because `PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE` is currently enabled, **every prospect today receives every capability regardless of plan**. Demonstrating Growth or Enterprise features to a Starter prospect is therefore easy — and dangerous, because it sets an expectation that will break the moment gating is switched on. Demo to the tier being quoted.

4.3 Which Features Acquire, Retain, and Expand

Not all capability carries the same commercial weight. This classification should drive demo sequencing, onboarding priorities, and roadmap arguments.

COMMERCIAL JOB	FEATURES THAT DO IT	IMPLICATION
Acquire wins the deal	Exclusive Bookings · Document & Employer Verification · Credential Expiry Tracking · AI Agreement Generation · Contract Health Score · AI Talent Matching	These belong in the first fifteen minutes of every demo. They are the only features that are genuinely hard to answer competitively.
Retain prevents churn	Spend & Hiring Analytics · Watchlist · Engagement Lists · Notifications · Direct Messaging · Post-Engagement Debrief · Reviews	Value accrues with usage and history. Drive adoption in onboarding — an account with no accumulated history is trivially cancellable.
Expand grows the account	Team Accounts · Team Analytics · Custom Clauses · Contract Redlining · Rate Suggestions · Meeting Brief · Token headroom	The expansion path is seats and AI consumption . Both are already instrumented, so upsell triggers can be built from existing data.
Supply liquidity enables everything	Cruise Mode · Earnings Intelligence · AI Proposal Generator · Public Profiles · Portfolio	Not directly monetised and should not be. These exist so the demand side has something to buy.

4.4 Demo Narrative

A twenty-minute sequence that follows the buyer's risk chronology rather than the product's navigation. Each step answers the question the previous step raises.

01 Describe the need AI match with explanations — not a filter grid	02 Prove the person Verified badges, licence expiry, DBS	03 Lock them in Booking flips availability live	04 Agree the rate Benchmark vs market and own history	05 Paper it AI contract, health score, dual sign	06 Show the ledger Spend, funnel, debrief, rehire advice
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THE DEMO MOMENT THAT CLOSSES

Step 3. Book a professional in front of the prospect and let them watch the Talent Vault update — the profile becomes unavailable, an availability block appears on the calendar, and it cannot be deleted. It takes fifteen seconds, requires no explanation, and no marketplace or ATS can reproduce it. Everything before step 3 earns the right to show it; everything after it justifies the price.

PART
05

Packaging, Pricing & Revenue Architecture

The plan structure as the code actually enforces it, what scales with customer value, where expansion revenue comes from, and what the AI features cost to serve.

5.1 Plan Architecture As Built

Six plan definitions exist. The figures below are taken from `artifacts/api-server/src/lib/plans.ts` — the only authoritative source, because it is the code that enforces the limits and renders the pricing page.

PLAN	AUDIENCE	PRICE	ACTIVE BOOKINGS	JOB POSTS / MONTH	EXPRESS INTERESTS	SEATS	TOKENS / MONTH	ROLE
free	Any	\$0	1	1	3	1	∞	Transitional default before a plan is chosen
freelancer_free	Freelancer	\$0	1	—	3	1	∞	Supply acquisition
freelancer_pro	Freelancer	\$0 was \$19	5	—	∞	1	∞	Supply monetisation SUSPENDED
employer_starter	Employer	\$49	2	5	—	1	50k	Only live price point
employer_growth	Employer	\$0 was \$199	10	∞	—	3	250k	Primary target tier SUSPENDED
employer_enterprise	Employer	Custom	∞	∞	—	∞	∞	Sales-led

∞ = no limit enforced. — = not applicable to that audience. Token limits apply to employer plans only; freelancer plans carry no token ceiling.

CRITICAL — INTERNAL DOCUMENTATION CONTRADICTS THE ENFORCING CODE

The plan table in `project.md` disagrees with `plans.ts` on four of six plans. Any quote, deck, or pricing page built from the documentation will be wrong.

PLAN	PROJECT.MD CLAIMS	PLANS.TS ENFORCES
freelancer_free	3 active bookings, 5 interests/mo	1 active booking, 3 interests/mo
freelancer_pro	10 active bookings	5 active bookings
employer_starter	3 active bookings	2 active bookings
employer_growth	15 active bookings, 30 job posts/mo	10 active bookings, unlimited job posts

The documentation also describes **five** plans; the code defines **six**, including a transitional `free` default that a new account holds before choosing. Reconcile to `plans.ts` and treat it as the single source of truth for all commercial material.

5.2 Value Metric Analysis

A good value metric rises with the customer's realised value, is predictable enough to budget, and is hard to game. TalentLock enforces four simultaneously, which is at least one too many.

METRIC	ALIGNED TO VALUE	PREDICTABLE FOR BUYER	ASSESSMENT
Active bookings	Strong	Strong	The right primary metric. It rises precisely with the value delivered — more concurrent engagements means more exclusivity, contracts, and assurance consumed. The buyer can forecast it. Keep as the headline ceiling.
AI tokens / month	Moderate	Weak	Correlates with cost to serve but not with buyer value, and no buyer can forecast token consumption. Useful as a fair-use backstop ; damaging if surfaced as a headline number in a quote.
Job posts / month	Moderate	Strong	Weakly tied to value — a posting that hires nobody creates none. Growth already relaxes this to unlimited, which is the correct direction. Consider removing entirely.
Team seats	Strong	Strong	Standard, well understood, and the natural expansion lever. Currently only meaningful at Growth (3) and Enterprise (unlimited); Starter is single-seat.
Express interests	Moderate	Strong	Supply-side only. Reasonable free-tier throttle, and the main reason a professional would consider upgrading.

RECOMMENDATION — SIMPLIFY TO TWO METRICS

Quote on **active bookings** and **seats**. Keep token ceilings as an internal fair-use guard described in terms of outcomes rather than tokens ("approximately N AI-assisted engagements per month"), and retire the job-post limit. Buyers cannot reason about tokens, and a quota expressed in units the customer does not understand converts a cost control into a trust problem the first time it is hit.

5.3 Entitlement Gating Map

Three gate functions control premium capability, each currently short-circuited by a single flag.

GATE	UNLOCKS AT	CAPABILITY BEHIND IT
hasEmployerGrowthFeatures()	GROWTH + ENT	AI rate suggestions, contract redlining, meeting-brief questions, debrief sections, per-conversation token breakdown
hasEmployerEnterpriseFeatures()	ENT	Team accounts, team analytics, custom agreement clauses
hasFreelancerProFeatures()	PRO	Cruise Mode activation, unlimited express interests

COMMERCIAL CONSEQUENCE OF THE OPEN FLAG

All three gates return `true` unconditionally while `PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE` is set, on both server and client. Every account therefore enjoys Enterprise capability at \$0. Three consequences follow:

1. **No upgrade pressure exists.** Nobody will ever hit a wall, so no self-serve expansion can occur.
2. **Expectation debt is accumulating.** Every current user is habituated to capability they are not paying for. Enabling gates later is a takeaway, and takeaways churn users.
3. **Margin is unprotected.** Token ceilings are the only bound on inference cost, and they are disabled — compounded by the absence of any request rate limit on AI endpoints.

Recommendation: enable gating before the user base grows further. The cost of the takeaway rises with every account added.

5.4 Land-and-Expand Mechanics

LAND	TRIGGER	EXPAND	TRIGGER	EXPAND
Starter \$49 1 seat · 2 bookings · 50k tokens	Booking ceiling 3rd concurrent engagement → 402	Growth 3 seats · 10 bookings · 250k	Seat + team need 4th user or shared shortlist	Enterprise Unlimited · custom clauses
EXPANSION TRIGGER	SIGNAL ALREADY CAPTURED	PLAY		
Booking ceiling reached	<code>402 PLAN_LIMIT</code> on booking create	Strongest trigger available — the customer is actively trying to do more business. Instrument it as a sales alert, not just a payroll redirect.		
Token consumption trend	<code>token_usage</code> monthly sums per account	Approaching the ceiling indicates deep AI adoption and high switching cost. Reach out before the wall, framed as headroom rather than overage.		
Second hiring manager appears	Team invite attempt; multiple users on one employer profile	Seat expansion. Enterprise gating on team accounts means this currently jumps straight from Growth to a sales-led motion — a large step.		
Watchlist saturation	Watchlist count vs plan limit (25 / 100)	Indicates pipeline building beyond current tier. A soft, non-blocking upgrade prompt.		
Redline or rate-suggestion attempt	Growth-gated feature interaction	Feature-led upsell at the exact moment of intent. Requires gating to be on to exist at all.		
Contract volume growth	Agreements executed per month	Retention and expansion evidence for a renewal conversation; also the best proxy for realised value.		

PACKAGING GAP — THE GROWTH-TO-ENTERPRISE CLIFF

Growth allows **3 seats**; the next step is Enterprise at custom pricing. A customer needing a fourth seat faces a sales-led negotiation rather than a self-serve increment. Worse, **team accounts, shared shortlist, and team analytics are all Enterprise-gated**, so the entire collaboration story is unavailable to the mid-market segment most likely to buy. Consider moving team accounts down to Growth and introducing per-seat pricing above the included three — that converts the cliff into a ramp and gives HR Operations a reason to advocate.

5.5 AI Cost to Serve & Gross Margin

Twenty inference surfaces make AI a real cost line, not a rounding error. The platform's accounting seam is well built; the controls around it are not yet switched on.

MARGIN FACTOR	STATUS	DETAIL
Per-account cost visibility	GOOD	Every inference call records prompt, completion, and total tokens against a user and a feature label. Cost per account is directly computable.
Per-feature cost visibility	GOOD	Twenty distinct labels allow unprofitable features to be identified individually.
Model tiering	GOOD	Cheaper <code>gpt-4o-mini</code> used for high-frequency assistive work; <code>gpt-4o</code> reserved for contract drafting, scoring, vision review, and agent evaluation.
Result caching	GOOD	Briefs, debriefs, summaries, and health scores are cached on the owning row and only invalidated when inputs change — repeat views are free.
Non-billable cost isolation	GOOD	Document verification is charged to an internal system account and employer document review is tracked but excluded from quota — platform obligations are deliberately separated from discretionary consumption.
Quota enforcement	OFF	Token ceilings are implemented with row-level locking, then bypassed by the open flag.
Rate limiting	ABSENT	No global limiter on AI endpoints. With quotas off, a single authenticated account can drive inference cost without bound.
Unmetered surface	GAP	Résumé parsing calls <code>gpt-4o</code> without recording usage — the only inference path invisible to cost reporting.
Agent cost governors	GOOD	Both autonomous agents carry hard budget caps — 6 evaluation-hours per day for TalentSearch, 10 messages per month for Cruise Mode — plus duplicate suppression and recipient caps. The most cost-exposed features are the best governed.

MARGIN ASSESSMENT

The architecture supports a healthy software gross margin: costs are attributable, results are cached, models are tiered, and the highest-volume automation is budget-capped. **The risk is operational, not structural.** Once quotas and a rate limit are enabled, the Starter tier's 50,000 monthly tokens becomes a genuine floor on cost per account, and per-feature data already exists to reprice or restrict any capability that proves unprofitable. Until then, cost per account should be monitored directly from `token_usage` rather than assumed.

5.6 Pricing Recommendations

1. **Reconcile the plan table to `plans.ts`** and publish a single internal pricing sheet. Until this is done, every quote is a guess.
2. **Remove the four unbuilt claims** from the pricing page — SSO/SCIM, audit log export, priority Vault placement, and the Pro badge — or build them. Advertising unbuilt capability at the Enterprise tier is the single largest commercial liability in the product today.
3. **Restore Growth to a real price** before the user base grows further. The \$49 to \$199 step is defensible on capability, but only if Growth capability is actually withheld from Starter.
4. **Raise Starter's booking ceiling from 2 to 3.** Two concurrent engagements is a very low ceiling for a \$49 product and risks reading as artificial rather than protective.
5. **Move team accounts from Enterprise to Growth** with three seats included and per-seat pricing above that, converting the Growth-to-Enterprise cliff into a ramp.
6. **Keep Freelancer Pro free** until verified supply exceeds employer demand, and remove its two unbuilt benefits immediately regardless.
7. **Express token limits as outcomes** in all customer-facing material, never as raw token counts.
8. **Do not introduce a take rate.** No payment rail exists, and the absence of a percentage cut is a decisive differentiator against staffing agencies — it should be defended as a positioning asset, not treated as unrealised revenue.

PART
06

Sales Enablement

The narrative, the questions that qualify, the objections that will come, and what can be claimed with evidence.

6.1 The Narrative Arc

Four moves. The purpose of each is to make the next one feel inevitable rather than to describe software.

MOVE 1 Name the failure they have already lived

"Most teams we speak to have had a contractor go quiet or take another project mid-delivery. Has that happened to you?" This is deliberately not a product statement. It establishes that the problem being solved is one they recognise, and it surfaces the specific incident that becomes the business case.

MOVE 2 Locate the gap in the tools they already pay for

"The marketplace introduced them, the e-signature tool signed something, the spreadsheet tracked the invoice. Which of those stopped them taking a second engagement, or told you their licence had expired?" The answer is none. This reframes TalentLock as filling a hole rather than replacing an incumbent — which protects it from a like-for-like price comparison.

MOVE 3 Demonstrate the lock

Book someone live. The Vault updates, the availability block appears, and it cannot be removed. Fifteen seconds, no narration required. This is the moment the category shifts in the buyer's mind from "another hiring tool" to "engagement assurance".

MOVE 4 Hand over the ledger

Spend by field, rate versus market, funnel conversion, retention, rehire recommendations. This is the move that converts a hiring-manager enthusiasm into a Finance-approved subscription, and it is what makes renewal a formality rather than a re-sale.

6.2 Discovery Questions By Persona

PERSONA	ASK	LISTENING FOR
Hiring Manager	How many specialist contractors are you running right now? · What happened the last time one didn't work out? · How do you currently know a credential is genuine and still valid?	A remembered failure with a cost attached; concurrency high enough to hit a booking ceiling
Founder / COO / Finance	What did you spend on contractors last year, and can you break it down by discipline? · How do you know a rate is fair? · Are you paying an agency percentage today?	No spend visibility; inconsistent rates; agency fees that a flat subscription displaces
Legal / Compliance	Who reviews contractor agreements before signature? · How would you evidence a current licence in an audit? · Where do signed agreements live?	Unreviewed templates; point-in-time credential checks; contracts in email or shared drives
HR / Talent Ops	How many managers hire contractors independently? · Is there a shared pipeline? · Can you report contractor hiring alongside permanent?	Fragmented process across managers; the seat and team-analytics expansion case
IT / Security	What does a tool holding identity documents need to satisfy here? · Is SSO mandatory or preferred?	Whether SSO is a hard requirement — if mandatory, disqualify or scope honestly as roadmap

PERSONA	ASK	LISTENING FOR
Education buyer	How do you currently track teaching licence and DBS expiry? · What happens operationally when a tutor double-books? · Who is accountable if an unlicensed teacher takes a session?	Named compliance owner with budget; the highest-urgency version of the pitch

6.3 Objection Handling

Each response below is grounded in a capability that genuinely exists, or concedes the gap plainly. **Do not improvise past a gap** — three of these objections concern things that are not built, and a confident wrong answer will surface in diligence.

"We already use a freelance marketplace and it's cheaper."

Agree, and separate the jobs. A marketplace introduces people; it does not stop the person you hired taking a parallel engagement, verify that a licence is still valid, draft or score your contract, or tell you afterwards whether the engagement was good value. **Also compare total cost honestly** — a percentage take rate on engagement value will typically exceed a flat subscription well before the year is out.

Evidence: exclusivity lock · expiry ladder · contract health score · no take rate

"Our agency handles vetting for us."

Agencies do vet well — and charge a margin on every hour for the privilege, while the vetting evidence stays with them rather than with you. TalentLock gives you the verification artefact and the audit trail directly, at a flat subscription, with the professional relationship held by you rather than intermediated.

Evidence: AI document verification · tiered badges · audit logging · flat pricing

"How is your AI matching better than everyone else's?"

Don't fight on this ground — every vendor claims it and buyers discount it. Redirect: "Matching is table stakes and I'd rather not compete on adjectives. What nobody else does is make the person unavailable to everyone else once you book them, and tell you when their licence is about to expire. Can I show you that instead?"

Tactic: concede the commodity, pivot to the differentiator

"Do you handle payments or escrow?"

No — concede immediately and cleanly. There is no payment rail and no processor integration. Position it as deliberate scope: TalentLock governs the engagement — verification, exclusivity, contract, outcome — and leaves invoicing to the systems finance already trusts. If escrow is a hard requirement, this is a genuine disqualifier today.

Gap — do not imply a roadmap date that has not been committed

"We need SSO. Our security policy requires it."

Not built. Say so. Authentication is handled by a managed identity provider, but there is no SAML or SCIM provisioning path. If SSO is mandatory, either disqualify or scope it as an explicit, dated roadmap commitment with engineering sign-off — never as an existing feature, even though the pricing page currently lists it.

Gap — pricing page claim must be corrected before enterprise conversations

"What's your uptime commitment?"

There is no contractual SLA today, and no monitoring instrumented to support one. Be straightforward about that and offer what does exist: an autoscaling deployment, a continuous integration suite covering the API surface, and a documented security posture. Do not invent a number.

Gap — no APM, tracing, or uptime metrics are wired

"This looks like a lot of product. Will my team actually use it?"

Fair challenge — narrow it. The daily surface is small: search, book, sign. The rest is either automatic (verification, expiry alerts, briefs, debriefs generate themselves) or reporting the buyer looks at monthly. Frame adoption around the three-step core and let the automation reveal itself.

Evidence: fire-and-forget automation · briefs and debriefs generated without user action

"Why is your \$199 tier free right now?"

Answer honestly: premium gating is temporarily open while billing is finalised. Then use it — this is a legitimate reason to sign now, and a real deadline. Do not pretend the list price is being charged; the prospect can see \$0 on the pricing page.

Context: `PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE` is enabled; Growth and Pro list at \$0

"Who else in our sector uses this?"

There are no named references yet. Do not manufacture them. Offer verifiable substance instead — a live demonstration on their own requirement, the specification and test coverage behind the product, and a pilot structured around one real engagement so they generate their own proof.

Gap — no customer references exist; pilots substitute for social proof

6.4 Proof Points We Can Stand Behind

CLAIM	STANDING	BASIS
"Exclusivity is enforced by the platform"	SOLID	Availability flips atomically on booking; booking-derived calendar blocks are immutable and rejected on delete
"Credentials are verified, not asserted"	SOLID	AI vision adjudication with confidence scoring and human escalation on low confidence
"We tell you before a licence expires"	SOLID	Daily scan with a forward-only 90/30/7-day ladder; expired education licences leave the Vault automatically
"A real contract, signed, in minutes"	SOLID	AI drafting, five-dimension scoring, dual e-signature, certified PDF with signature images and timestamps
"You can see what you spend and whether it was fair"	SOLID	Spend analytics, rate benchmarking against market median and own history, hiring funnel and retention metrics
"Hire in any currency"	SOLID	Country-derived currency, booking currency frozen with an FX snapshot, dual-currency display
"Built for education hiring"	SOLID	Four profession types, subject/level matching, DBS status, licence expiry enforcement, per-type document requirements, session and course rate types
"Enterprise-ready security"	QUALIFY	Per-resource authorisation, deny-by-default object access, CSRF protection, log redaction, audit trail and GDPR deletion are all real — but there is no SSO, no penetration test, and no security documentation pack . Claim the controls, not the label.
"Trusted by teams like yours"	DO NOT	No customers, references, or usage data exist. Unsupportable.
"SSO, SCIM, audit export"	DO NOT	Advertised on the pricing page but absent from the codebase
"99.x% uptime"	DO NOT	No monitoring or availability measurement exists to substantiate any figure

6.5 Competitive Traps

- **Being drawn into a matching bake-off.** Matching quality is unprovable in a demo and every competitor claims it. Concede it as table stakes and move to exclusivity.
- **Being priced against a take rate.** Insist on total-cost-of-engagement arithmetic; a percentage of engagement value overtakes a flat subscription quickly.
- **Letting an agency reframe verification as service.** The counter is ownership: with an agency the vetting evidence and the relationship both stay with the agency.
- **Demonstrating gated features to a Starter prospect.** Trivially easy today because gates are open, and it manufactures a downgrade experience at contract time.
- **Accepting an SSO requirement to keep a deal alive.** It will fail security review. Losing the deal at qualification is far cheaper than losing it at diligence.
- **Promising payment or escrow “soon”.** No rail exists and none is scoped. This creates a commitment the roadmap has not accepted.

PART
07

Go-to-Market & Commercial Readiness

How each segment should be approached, where the funnel already has leverage, and precisely what stands between the product and its first invoice.

7.1 Motion By Segment

SEGMENT	MOTION	ENTRY PLAN	APPROACH
Professionals (supply)	Self-serve	FREE	Zero-friction signup gated only by profile completeness and identity upload. Seed deliberately by category ahead of demand — an employer who searches an empty category does not return. Retain with Earnings Intelligence and Cruise Mode.
Solo & small teams	Self-serve + light touch	STARTER	Product-led. The demo can be self-guided; the booking ceiling of two creates a natural expansion trigger quickly. Requires payment collection to function at all.
Mid-market	Sales-assisted	GROWTH	The core commercial target. One demo plus a pilot on a real engagement. Champion is the hiring manager; Finance signs. Address HR Ops explicitly — currently under-served because team features sit in Enterprise.
Education institutions	Sales-led, vertical	GROWTH	Highest-conviction segment. Lead with compliance: licence expiry, DBS, double-booking prevention. The buyer has a named accountable owner. Reference customers here compound fastest.
Enterprise	Sales-led	ENT	Defer. SSO/SCIM, audit export, an SLA, and a security pack are all absent, and two of those are currently advertised. Entering this segment now risks a failed security review and reputational cost. Revisit once the enterprise gap list is closed.

7.2 Activation Funnel & Conversion Levers

The product already imposes several hard gates. Each is a conversion risk **and** a quality filter, and each is worth instrumenting before spending on acquisition.

FUNNEL STAGE	GATE IN THE PRODUCT	COMMERCIAL READING
Signup	Managed identity provider; new users receive a deliberate “not found” and are routed to onboarding	Low friction. Nothing to fix.
Registration completion	Mandatory identity document upload before a role is assigned	The single largest drop-off risk on both sides. It is also the source of the trust differentiator, so it should not be removed — but it must be measured, and the value of verification should be explained at the point of the ask rather than after it.
Supply activation	Vault visibility requires completenessScore ≥ 60	Correct trade-off: protects buyer experience at the cost of supply volume. The completeness checklist already exists to guide users over the line.
Employer first value	First search, first watchlist save, first booking	Time-to-first-booking is the metric that matters. Everything before it is cost.

FUNNEL STAGE	GATE IN THE PRODUCT	COMMERCIAL READING
Habit formation	Notifications, messaging, watchlist alerts, engagement lists	Strong retention surface, but it only engages once an account has real engagements in flight.
Expansion	402 at the booking ceiling; Growth-gated features	Currently inert — with gates open nobody reaches a wall, so self-serve expansion cannot occur.
Payment	Simulated upgrade transition	Hard stop. The funnel cannot convert to revenue at all.

INSTRUMENTATION GAP

There is no product analytics, funnel tracking, or account-health scoring in the platform. Token consumption, activity ledgers, and audit logs exist and can be queried, but nobody can currently answer “what fraction of signups complete registration?” or “how long until an account's first booking?”. **Instrument the funnel before spending on acquisition** — otherwise acquisition spend cannot be evaluated, and the document-upload drop-off in particular will remain invisible.

7.3 Revenue Blockers

Four items stand between this product and its first invoice. None require architectural change.

#	BLOCKER	OWNER	ACTION REQUIRED
1	No payment collection	Engineering	Integrate a processor into the existing upgrade surface and the reserved <code>subscriptions</code> columns. The API shape already anticipates this; it is an integration, not a redesign. Nothing can be sold until this ships.
2	Four unbuilt claims on the pricing page	Product & Marketing	Remove SSO/SCIM, audit log export, priority Vault placement, and the Pro badge from the plan feature arrays — or build them. This is a content change measured in minutes and is the highest-leverage risk reduction available.
3	Entitlement gates disabled	Engineering	Set <code>PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE</code> and <code>VITE_PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE</code> to <code>false</code> , restore list prices, and verify the <code>402</code> paths against the existing integration suite. Do this before the user base grows, since the takeaway cost compounds.
4	Pricing documentation conflict	Product	Reconcile the plan table to <code>plans.ts</code> and publish one internal pricing sheet as the single source of truth for quotes and collateral.

Strongly recommended before scaling, though not strictly blocking

- **Global rate limit on AI endpoints** — with quotas off, inference cost per account is unbounded. This is a margin exposure that grows with every signup.
- **Meter the résumé parser** — the only inference path invisible to cost reporting.
- **Funnel instrumentation** — without it, acquisition spend cannot be assessed.
- **Security documentation pack** — the controls exist; the evidence package for a buyer's security review does not.
- **Move team accounts to Growth** — removes the seat cliff and gives HR Operations a reason to advocate in mid-market deals.

7.4 Commercial Risk Register

RISK	SEVERITY	LIKELIHOOD	MITIGATION
Selling unbuilt enterprise capability	High	High	Correct the pricing page now. Until then, prohibit enterprise conversations that touch SSO, SCIM, or audit export.

RISK	SEVERITY	LIKELIHOOD	MITIGATION
Cannot collect revenue	High	Certain	Payment integration is the top engineering priority with commercial consequence.
Expectation debt from open gates	Medium	High	Enable gating early; grandfather existing accounts explicitly and deliberately rather than by accident.
Quoting from stale documentation	Medium	High	One authoritative pricing sheet generated from <code>plans.ts</code> .
Unbounded AI cost per account	Medium	Medium	Rate limit plus re-enabled quotas; monitor cost per account from <code>token_usage</code> in the interim.
Supply liquidity gap by category	High	Medium	Seed supply per category before selling into it. An employer who searches an empty category churns immediately and rarely returns.
Registration drop-off at document upload	Medium	Medium	Instrument it, then explain the verification benefit at the point of the ask. Do not remove the gate — it is the differentiator.
Mis-filed into a cheaper category	Medium	Medium	Claim “engagement assurance” explicitly in the first meeting and lead with exclusivity, never with matching.
No references or social proof	Medium	Certain	Structure early deals as pilots on one real engagement so the customer generates their own proof; convert the first education win into a reference deliberately.
No SLA or uptime evidence	Medium	Medium	Instrument availability before offering any commitment. Decline SLA requests honestly in the interim.

CLOSING COMMERCIAL ASSESSMENT

TalentLock is a **product-ready, commercially unfinished** business. The capability inventory is broad, differentiated, and genuinely hard to replicate in the two places that matter most — enforced exclusivity and continuous credential compliance. The education vertical offers a segment where those differentiators are mandatory rather than merely attractive, which is the fastest available path to a defensible reference base.

The constraint is not the product. It is a missing payment integration, a configuration flag, four lines of inaccurate marketing copy, and one contradictory table. **Every blocker on the critical path to revenue is measured in days of work, not quarters** — and the single most urgent of them, removing capability claims that cannot be honoured, costs nothing but the decision to do it.

APPX

A

Capability-to-Value Index

All 48 shipped capabilities in numerical order with their commercial job, audience, and entitlement tier. Use as a quick-reference during discovery.

#	CAPABILITY	AUDIENCE	TIER	JOB	COMMERCIAL ONE-LINER
01	Dual Role System	Both	ALL	Enable	Verified onboarding for both sides of the engagement
02	Talent Vault	Employer	ALL	Acquire	Shortlist from pre-qualified, quality-gated supply
03	Exclusive Bookings	Employer	ALL	Acquire	They cannot be taken by someone else
04	Rate Negotiation	Both	ALL	Acquire	No work begins on an unagreed rate
05	AI Talent Matching	Employer	ALL	Acquire	Describe the need instead of filtering a directory
06	AI Agreement Generation	Employer	ALL	Acquire	A real contract in minutes, not legal cycles
07	Signature Upload	Both	ALL	Retain	Sign once, reuse across every agreement
08	Agreement Safe Locker	Both	ALL	Retain	Certified copy for both parties on execution
09	Milestone Tracking	Both	ALL	Retain	Delivery visible without a status meeting
10	Reviews & Ratings	Both	ALL	Retain	Reputation grounded in completed engagements
11	Portfolio	Freelancer	ALL	Supply	Evidence of quality alongside verified identity
12	Public Profiles	Freelancer	ALL	Supply	Shareable profile; light organic acquisition
13	Availability Calendar	Both	ALL	Acquire	Know availability before making an offer
14	Subscription Tiers	Both	ALL	Monetise	Predictable cost, no take rate on the work
15	Admin Console	Internal	INT	Operate	Human-in-the-loop verification at scale
16	Document Verification	Freelancer	ALL	Acquire	Credentials checked, not asserted
17	AI Token Tracking	Employer	GROWTH	Expand	Transparent AI consumption, not an opaque cost
18	Agreement Templates	Employer	ENT	Expand	Consistent terms across the organisation
19	Contract Redlining	Employer	GROWTH	Expand	Improve terms without a legal review cycle
20	Job Description Assistant	Employer	ALL	Retain	Better postings attract better candidates
21	Smarter Matching	Employer	ALL	Acquire	Recommendations you can justify to a colleague
22	Notifications Centre	Both	ALL	Retain	Nothing waits on someone remembering to check
23	Earnings Intelligence	Freelancer	ALL	Supply	Why professionals keep their profile current

#	CAPABILITY	AUDIENCE	TIER	JOB	COMMERCIAL ONE-LINER
24	Spend Analytics	Employer	ALL	Retain	Contractor spend reportable to a board
25	Hiring Analytics	Employer	ALL	Retain	Manage hiring as a process, not a favour
26	Security Hardening	Both	ALL	Enable	Survives a security questionnaire
27	Product Gaps package	Both	ALL	Retain	Email, search, pagination — usability at volume
28	AI Proposal Generator	Freelancer	ALL	Supply	Better-quality responses to employers
29	Smart Rate Suggestions	Employer	GROWTH	Expand	Stop overpaying and stop underbidding
30	Team Accounts	Employer	ENT	Expand	Coordinated hiring with consolidated reporting
31	Contract Health Score	Both	ALL	Acquire	Non-lawyers can judge contract quality
32	Auth Hardening	Both	ALL	Enable	Per-resource authorisation; IDOR protection
33	Agreement AI Summary	Freelancer	ALL	Supply	Professionals sign understanding the terms
34	Agreement PDF Download	Both	ALL	Retain	An artefact finance and legal accept
35	Cruise Mode	Freelancer	PRO	Supply	Autonomous pitching while they work
36	Teaching Professional Profile	Freelancer	ALL	Acquire	Education modelled, not adapted
37	TalentSearch	Employer	ALL	Acquire	Sourcing continues while you work
38	AI Meeting Brief	Employer	GROWTH	Expand	Every interview prepared, even unprepared
39	Discovery Meeting Outcome	Employer	ALL	Retain	Interview knowledge retained by the organisation
40	In-App Direct Messaging	Both	ALL	Retain	Conversation attached to the engagement
41	Employer Verification	Employer	ALL	Acquire	Professionals can see the employer is real
42	Credential Expiry Tracking	Freelancer	ALL	Acquire	Compliance continuous, not point-in-time
43	Freelancer Watchlist	Employer	START	Retain	Warm bench for the next requirement
44	Post-Engagement AI Debrief	Both	GROWTH	Expand	Institutional memory of who to rehire
45	Multi-Currency & Location	Both	ALL	Enable	Hire across borders without spreadsheets
46	Employer Uploaded Agreement	Employer	ALL	Acquire	Keep your own paper, gain the workflow
47	Job Timeline Validation	Employer	ALL	Enable	Removes a recurring scheduling dispute
48	Engagement Lists	Both	ALL	Retain	Usable at volume as the account grows

Bold entries are the six capabilities that most reliably differentiate in a competitive conversation. Tiers reflect gates as written in code and are currently all open by configuration.

APPX
B

Plan Comparison Matrix

Customer-facing comparison built from `plans.ts`. Suitable as the basis for a pricing sheet once the unbuilt claims are removed.

CAPABILITY	FREELANCER FREE	FREELANCER PRO	EMPLOYER STARTER	EMPLOYER GROWTH	EMPLOYER ENTERPRISE
Monthly price	\$0	\$0 (was \$19)	\$49	\$0 (was \$199)	Custom
Active bookings	1	5	2	10	∞
Job posts / month	—	—	5	∞	∞
Express interests / month	3	∞	—	—	—
Team seats	1	1	1	3	∞
AI tokens / month	∞	∞	50k	250k	∞
Watchlist entries	—	—	25	100	Shared shortlist
Talent Vault listing	✓	✓	—	—	—
Exclusivity lock	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Document verification	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Credential expiry alerts	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
AI agreement generation	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Contract health score	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Dual e-signature + PDF	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Spend & hiring analytics	—	—	✓	✓	✓
Contract redlining	—	—	×	✓	✓
AI rate suggestions	—	—	×	✓	✓
AI meeting brief questions	—	—	×	✓	✓
Post-engagement debrief (full)	—	—	×	✓	✓
Per-conversation token detail	—	—	×	✓	✓
Cruise Mode agent	×	✓	—	—	—
TalentSearch agent	—	—	✓	✓	✓
Team accounts & shortlist	—	—	×	×	✓
Team analytics	—	—	×	×	✓
Custom agreement clauses	—	—	×	×	✓
SSO / SCIM	—	—	×	×	×
Audit log export	—	—	×	×	×

CAPABILITY	FREELANCER FREE	FREELANCER PRO	EMPLOYER STARTER	EMPLOYER GROWTH	EMPLOYER ENTERPRISE
Priority Vault placement NOT BUILT	×	×	—	—	—
Verified Pro badge NOT BUILT	×	×	—	—	—
Payments / escrow NOT BUILT	×	×	×	×	×

✓ included · × excluded · — not applicable to that audience. Rows shaded red are currently advertised on the pricing page but absent from the product; they must be removed or built before this matrix is used with customers. All gated rows are presently unlocked for every plan because PREMIUM_FEATURES_FREE is enabled.

APPX
C

Claims Discipline

A single reference for what customer-facing teams may state as fact, what must be qualified, and what must not be said at all.

STATEMENT	VERDICT	REQUIRED FRAMING
Booking makes a professional exclusively unavailable	SAY IT	Demonstrate live; it is enforced in the data model
Identity and credentials are AI-verified with human escalation	SAY IT	Accurate; low-confidence results route to an admin review queue
Expiring licences trigger staged alerts	SAY IT	90/30/7-day ladder; expired education licences leave the Vault
Contracts are drafted, scored, signed and issued as PDF in-platform	SAY IT	Complete lifecycle; no external e-signature tool required
Spend and rate benchmarking are available	SAY IT	Against market median and the customer's own history
Multi-currency hiring is supported	SAY IT	Booking currency frozen with an FX snapshot at creation
Purpose-built for education hiring	SAY IT	Profession types, subject/level matching, DBS, licence expiry, session rates
"Enterprise-ready"	QUALIFY	Name the controls that exist. Do not use the phrase as a shorthand — it implies SSO and an SLA, neither of which exist
Plan limits and prices	QUALIFY	Quote only from <code>plans.ts</code> . Growth and Pro currently list at \$0
Premium features included	QUALIFY	Currently open to all plans by configuration. State that it is temporary, in writing
SSO, SCIM, audit log export	DO NOT	Not implemented. Remove from the pricing page; never quote
Priority Vault placement, Verified Pro badge	DO NOT	No ranking or badge logic reads the plan
Payments, escrow, invoicing	DO NOT	No payment rail exists in any form
Uptime or availability figures	DO NOT	Nothing is instrumented to measure or substantiate a number
Customer counts, logos, references, case studies	DO NOT	None exist. Use pilots so the customer generates their own evidence
Penetration test or certification status	DO NOT	No third-party assessment has been performed

STANDING INSTRUCTION

Four capabilities are currently advertised on the live pricing page and are not implemented: **SSO/SCIM, audit log export, priority Vault placement, and the Verified Pro badge**. Until the pricing page is corrected, treat everything rendered there as unverified and quote exclusively from this document's Appendix B. If a prospect raises one of these four, correct the record immediately — an early, honest correction costs a feature; a late one discovered in diligence costs the deal and the relationship.